

Metaphor and register

A Multiple meanings of phrasal verbs

A phrasal verb can have a number of different meanings, e.g.

He **got on** the bus.
[entered the bus]

get on

Jim and Ian **get on** really well.
[like each other and are friendly]

Shh! I'm trying to **get on** with my work.
[continue doing my work]

Often there is no direct connection between the various meanings and you just have to learn each different meaning of the phrasal verb. The best way to do this is by trying to remember a sentence using the phrasal verb.

B Literal and metaphorical meaning

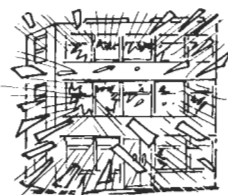
Sometimes the basic meanings of a phrasal verb and the additional meanings are clearly linked. This is because some additional meanings are based on a metaphor or image which has a direct connection with its literal or basic meaning. A metaphor is a way of expressing something by comparing it with something else that has similar characteristics. Here is an example:

LITERAL (BASIC) MEANING

blow up a balloon
inflate or fill with air



blow up a building
make it explode



METAPHORICAL MEANING

someone **blows up**
suddenly becomes very angry



Sometimes a phrasal verb only exists as a phrasal verb in the metaphorical meaning, but you can guess what it means from the meaning of the basic verb without the particle. For example: These statistics look strange. Have we **slipped up** somewhere?

Here **slip up** [make a mistake] clearly comes from **slip** [fall usually because the floor is wet or the ground is icy].

C Register

Another important aspect of phrasal verbs is register. Phrasal verbs are typical of spoken English or informal writing, e.g. letters to friends and articles in popular journalism. There are often one-word equivalents, or synonyms, for use in a more formal spoken or written style. For example: **miss out** a question *or* **omit** a question. See section 2C in Unit 2 for other examples.

As with all English vocabulary, there are some different uses from one geographical area to another. For example, British, American and Australian users of English all talk of **clearing up** a room [putting things away tidily], but only British and Australian speakers would use **tidy up** as a synonym.

See Unit 69 for more examples of how phrasal verbs differ in North America and Australia.

Exercises

5.1 Match the different meanings a–f of *take in* with the appropriate sentences 1–6 below.

- a) make smaller
 - b) allow in through a hole
 - c) deceive
 - d) give a bed to
 - e) include
 - f) understand the meaning or importance
- 1 Because so many passengers were stranded at the airport, some local families offered to take them in overnight.
 - 2 The news is so shocking – I still can't take it in.
 - 3 The excursion will take in two of the most beautiful castles in the region.
 - 4 Marie has lost weight – she's going to have to take in a lot of her clothes.
 - 5 Rob was totally dishonest but he was so charming that I was taken in by him.
 - 6 We'd better return to the shore at once – the boat seems to be taking in water.

5.2 These pairs of sentences show phrasal verbs which can be used in both literal and metaphorical ways. Explain the two meanings and the connection between them.

- 1 a) I **stepped in** a puddle of water and my feet are soaking now.
b) She **stepped in** to stop the argument from becoming more serious.
- 2 a) This programme is rubbish. I wish you'd **switch off** the TV.
b) The lecture was so boring that I **switched off**.
- 3 a) There's a hole in my bag. I think my pen must have **dropped out**.
b) He **dropped out** of college and became a mechanic.
- 4 a) We **tied the boxes down** on the roof of the car.
b) Mark dreams of travelling but he feels **tied down** by his family and work responsibilities.

5.3 Use your knowledge of the basic verb in the underlined phrasal verbs as well as the context of the sentence in order to work out the meanings of the phrasal verbs.

- 1 What are you driving at? I wish you would say exactly what you mean!
- 2 The teacher did all she could to drum the vocabulary into her pupils before the exam.
- 3 The old education system used to cream off the best pupils and teach them in separate schools.
- 4 The noise of the children's music completely drowned out the television.

5.4 Write a one-word formal equivalent for each of the underlined phrasal verbs.

As the rain didn't let up, the football game was called off. So the team got down to discussing its strategy for the next match instead. We didn't get out of the clubhouse until the cleaners turned up in the evening.

FOLLOW UP

If you encounter a phrasal verb that you thought you knew but it does not seem to make sense, use other clues in the context to work out what the meaning might be. It may be quite different from the meaning that you already knew.